Where did the water go?

A Kitchen Sponge

Name _____ Date _____



Little Wonderer peered through a magnifier at a kitchen sponge. A sponge is a soft material that can take in water. “It is full of holes!” Little said. “Those holes are pores,” said Big. Inside, many spaces connect like little tunnels. Little wondered where a spill would go.



Big dipped the sponge into a shallow dish. Its lower edge grew darker. Water clung to the sponge’s walls and crept into narrow gaps. This slow spreading is called wicking. To soak up, or absorb, means to take water in. The water was entering the spaces inside.



Big lifted the sponge over an empty cup. “Where is the water now?” asked Little. Big gave a gentle squeeze: a press from both sides. The spaces became smaller, pushing water out. Drops fell into the cup. The water had not vanished. Little could see it again.

sponge	a soft material full of spaces that can take in water
pores	tiny holes leading into spaces in the sponge
soak	take water into a material
squeeze	press from the sides to make something smaller
spring back	return to an open shape after being pressed
absorb	take in water or another liquid

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Next they compared two same-size pieces. One was bone-dry; the other was damp, with a little water already inside. Each met the same small spill for the same time. The damp piece soaked up its spill faster. That often happens, but different sponges can behave differently. A fair test helps us find out.



Big let go after another squeeze. The sponge began to spring back, returning to its open shape. Its spaces opened too, ready to take in water again. “Smaller, then open,” Little said. The sponge changed shape, but the water stayed water. Little sketched the cup beside it.



“Is our sponge an animal?” Little asked. “Sea sponges are simple animals,” said Big. “People make most kitchen sponges from cellulose, a plant fibre, or foam.” Little drew holes in the notebook. “How much could ours hold?”

1. Where did the water go before Big squeezed the sponge?
2. How does a squeeze change the spaces, and what happens when Big lets go?
3. How could you fairly compare a dry sponge and a damp one?

Your turn

Write one command sentence about the sponge test.

Example: Dip the sponge in the water, then squeeze it over the empty cup.